Usability Results:

Usability Analysis of Sears' Website

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USABILITY RESULTS:

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INTRODUCTION

Sears is an American retailer of general merchandise, tools, home appliances, clothing, and automotive parts and services. In 2005, Sears was acquired by Kmart and each became subsidiaries of the newly formed Sears Holding Corporation, the third largest retailer in the United States. And later, in 2019, a federal judge approved the sale of the holding company to Edward S. Lampert's hedge fund, ESL investments.

The following usability tests evaluate a total of 27 participants, based on their satisfaction or dissatisfaction in using the www.sears.com website, analyzing responses based on a number of methods. The research conducted will help to critique the current Sears website, provide recommendations for their desktop and mobile interfaces, as well as provide wireframes and design mockups which illustrate these recommendations.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

METHODOLOGY

First, an Unmoderated Remote Usability Test (URUT) with 20 short-answer questions was given to 17 college students at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill. This test asked questions about the participants' background, occupation and internet use, then followed with specific questions regarding the Sears website - in both desktop and mobile contexts. After test completion, the participants' responses were organized and analyzed and the data collected was used to create two tables which denote the pain and pleasure points users experienced while navigating the site. The top three categories of concern for each were highlighted.

Using the three categories of concern from the URUTs, a second test, called a Rating Test, was conducted. A new set of participants, 5 college students from the University of Connecticut, were selected to complete this round of testing. The participants were asked to navigate the Sears website for 5 to 8 minutes before ranking the categories of concern on a scale of 1 to 10, where 1, described categories that didn't need much improvement, and 10, described categories that needed the most improvement.

A third test, a Card Sort Experiment, was conducted using another 5 participants, different from the previous two testing pools. After being given 5 to 8 minutes to navigate the website, participants were given 7 cards to rank in order of customer importance, with 1 being the category most important to the participant, and 7 being the category least important. Each card's rank, as assigned by each participant, was aggregated resulting in a cumulative value for such a card. The lower this value, the more popular the category.

PARTICIPANTS

In total, the research pool consisted of 27 participants. 17 students from the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill participated in the URUT. The Rating Test participants consisted of the following University of Connecticut students: Mike Connor, Kyle Martens, Julia Caranjelo, Katie

Flood and Olivia Hoffman. The Card Sort Experiment's participants were as follows: Tamu Lewis, Kayla Burke, Zara Thorpe, Liz Lewis, and Eli Stockman.

VALUE PROPOSITION

Sears aims to provide a wide range of high quality, moderately priced goods and services to the everyday American customer, as communicated in their internal motto: "Sears is a family store for middle class, home-owning America. We are not a fashion store. We are not a store for the whimsical, nor the affluent."

CUSTOMER SEGMENT

Based on the data collected from the URUT, the target audience for the Sears company is anyone who is a homeowner or living as a non-dependent in the United States; roughly anyone between the ages of 18 and 70. The participants tested in the URUT, the Rating Test and the Card Sort Experiment included participants that were a combination of college students and older adults that spanned the age range of the target audience.

USABILITY TESTING I - Unmoderated Remote Usability Test (URUT)

TEST OBJECTIVE

The objective of the URUT was to gauge which sections of the Sears website were most and least favoured by the participants. The top categories of concern would be used in further testing strategies, seen throughout this report.

DATA COLLECTED

Qualitative data was collected from the URUT in the form of direct responses provided from the test's participants. These findings helped gauge which aspects of the Sears website the participants found satisfactory or less satisfactory. The comments or questions provided in this test served as the basis for creating the categories that would be later used to develop pain and pleasure point tables.

Quantitative data was also collected and was measured by the number of participants who agreed with the categories of pain and pleasure points respectively.

UNMODERATED REMOTE USABILITY TEST (URUT)

PAIN POINTS I

CATEGORY	NUMBER OF PARTICIPANTS	TOP 3 CATEGORIES OF CONCERN
Hyperfocus on Ads/Discounts/Promotions	11	
Overcrowdedness	7	
Visual Design	7	
Hierarchy of Information	11	
(Lack of) Student Appeal	8	
Layout	4	

Figure 1

*Figure 1: Pain Points I shows that there were 6 negative comments among UNC Chapel Hill student URUTs. The top 3 categories of concern are highlighted in yellow.

PLEASURE POINTS I

CATEGORIES	NUMBER OF PARTICIPANTS	TOP 3 CATEGORIES OF CONCERN
Site Navigation	7	
Alternative Methods for Completing Tasks	6	
Student Appeal	4	
Presentation of Information	3	
Hierarchy of Information	2	
Visual Design	7	
Tone	2	

Figure 2

*Figure 2: Pleasure Points I shows that there were 7 positive comments among UNC Chapel Hill student URUTs. The top 3 categories of concern are highlighted in yellow.

USABILITY TESTING II - Rating Test

TEST OBJECTIVE

The objective of the second usability test, the Rating Test, was to figure out which of the three categories of concern, for both the pain and pleasure points, was most important to the user.

DATA COLLECTED

Five college students from the University of Connecticut were asked to browse the Sears website briefly and then rate each of these three categories on a scale of 1-10. The data collected was mainly quantitative, as number values provided by test participants out of 10 were aggregated and then averaged for each category.

RATING TEST

PAIN POINTS II

PARTICIPANT	AGE	CATEGORY	RATING	AVGS
Mike Connor	22			
		Hyperfocus on Ads/Discounts/ Promotions	7	
		Poor Hierarchy of Information	9	
		(Lack of) Student Appeal	5	
Kyle Martens	21			
		Hyperfocus on Ads/Discounts/ Promotions	6	
		Poor Hierarchy of Information	8	
		(Lack of) Student Appeal	4	
Julia Carangelo	21			
		Hyperfocus on Ads/Discounts/ Promotions	7	

		Poor Hierarchy of Information	8	
		(Lack of) Student Appeal	6	
Katie Flood	19			
		Hyperfocus on Ads/Discounts/ Promotions	5	
		Poor Hierarchy of Information	9	
		(Lack of) Student Appeal	7	
Olivia Hoffman	22			
		Hyperfocus on Ads/Discounts/ Promotions	8	
		Poor Hierarchy of Information	7	
		(Lack of) Student Appeal	4	
			CATEGORIES	AVGS
			Hyperfocus on Ads/Discounts/Promotions	6.6
			Poor Hierarchy of Information	8.2
			(Lack of) Student Appeal	5.2

Figure 3

*Figure 3: Pain Points II illustrates that participants felt that poor hierarchy of information is the category that deserves the most improvement going forward.

PLEASURE POINTS II

PARTICIPANT	AGE	CATEGORY	RATING	AVGS
Mike Connor	22			
		Website Navigation	6	
		Alternative Methods for Completing Tasks	7	
		Visual Design	7	
Kyle Martens	21			
		Website Navigation	5	
		Alternative Methods for Completing Tasks	8	
		Visual Design	8	
Julia Carangelo	21			
		Website Navigation	5	
		Alternative Methods for Completing Tasks	7	
		Visual Design	7	
Katie Flood	19			
		Website Navigation	7	
		Alternative Methods for Completing Tasks	8	

		Visual Design	7	
Olivia Hoffman	22			
		Website Navigation	6	
		Alternative Methods for Completing Tasks	6	
		Visual Design	8	
			CATEGORIES	AVGS
			Website Navigation	5.8
			Alternative Methods for Completing Tasks	7.2
			Visual Design	7.4

Figure 4

*Figure 4: Pleasure Points II illustrates that participants felt that visual design required the least improvement going forward.

ANALYSIS AND RESULTS I - URUT & Rating Test

PAIN POINT

The analysis of the URUT showed that our users were mainly concerned with a hyperfocus on advertisements, promotions and discounts, poor hierarchy of visual information and a lack of student appeal as the main pain points. After delving deeper into these concerns, by conducting our Rating Test, it was clear that among these pain points, the Sears website's poor hierarchy of visual information was the area that our participants felt needed the most help or development going forward. This was demonstrated by an average rating value of 8.2 out of 10 as illustrated by the results of the Rating Test.

PLEASURE POINT

In the URUT, our users indicated that website navigation, visual design and the availability of alternative methods for completing tasks were major pleasure points for the Sears website interface. And while conducting the Rating Test, we learned that users favored visual design and alternative tasks more than website navigation. These were the areas we tried to keep intact, especially as we moved to recommend changes, which will be seen in more detail later in this report. This was demonstrated by an average rating of 7.4 out of 10 as illustrated by the results of the Rating Test.

USABILITY TESTING III - Card Sort Experiment

TESTING OBJECTIVE

The objective of the Card Sort Experiment was to understand how users would prefer the visual hierarchy of information to be presented. Participants, in previous rounds of testing, had identified that this feature was the area that needed the most improvement.

DATA COLLECTED

The data collected during the card sort experiment was largely quantitative. The number values provided by the experiment's participants, from 1 to 7, were aggregated and then averaged for each category. This information was used to determine where each category would be placed in the visual hierarchy of information on the website's desktop and mobile interfaces.

CARD SORT EXPERIMENT

	PARTICIPANTS				
CARD CATEGORIES	Tamu	Kayla	Zara	Liz	Eli
Appliances	3	2	1	5	1
Ads/Deals/Promotions	1	1	2	2	2
Tools from Sears	2	3	3	3	4
Lawn + Garden	6	6	5	4	3
Clothing	4	5	4	1	6
Fitness + Sports	5	4	6	6	5
Repairs	7	7	7	7	7

CARD CATEGORIES	TOTALS
Ads/Deals/Promotions	8
Appliances	12
Tools from Sears	15
Lawn + Garden	24
Clothing	20
Fitness + Sport	26
Repairs	35

Figure 5

*Figure 5 illustrates the order of importance to users of each of the card categories: Ads/Deals/Promotions, Appliances, Tools from Sears, Clothing, Lawn + Garden, Fitness + Sport and Repairs.

ANALYSIS AND RESULTS II - Card Sort Experiment

CARD SORT EXPERIMENT RESULTS

Using a ranking card system, with the appropriate allocation of points, we were able to determine what the optimal order of display would be for the organization of Sears' various goods and services. Poor visual hierarchy of information was the category that was identified by participants in the Rating Test as the most problematic area of the website and we built on those concerns here.

The card sort experiment demonstrated the users' preferences for card categories such as "Appliances" and "Tools from Sears" and showed a lesser preference for categories like "Repairs". The low number of 8 which was attributed to preference for "Ads/Deals/Promotions" was surprising in the sense that it was a major pain point recorded in the URUTs. In this usability test, participants valued this category highly compared to the other cards, presumably because ads, promotions and discounts contribute to the value proposition offered by Sears to cater to the average American, who would benefit from discounted prices.

RECOMMENDATIONS

It is important to note that across the different usability tests, our participants generally did not indicate a preference to use either the desktop or mobile versions of the Sears' websites. Therefore, the recommendations provided here, can be attributed to both interfaces and are shown to be the same or mostly similar, in the provided wireframes.

1. First, we proposed a complete reorganization of the website's visual hierarchy of information so that it was more representative of the interests of our participants, as determined by the results of the card sort experiment. Items would now appear in the following order: Ads/Promotions/Discounts, Appliances, Tools from Sears, Clothing, Lawn + Garden, Fitness + Sport and Repair.
2. After 11 out of 17 participants in the URUTs described the hyperfocus on ads, promotions and discounts as a major pain point, it would have been easy to remove them entirely from the homepage. But after diving more deeply into the interests of other participants across other tests, we wanted to keep them to honor the company's value proposition - to offer goods and services at competitive prices for the average American. So, we made a change in the organization of this card category on the website in order to make it more user friendly; a separate box where ads, promotions and discounts could be kept, sorted by the demographic who can use it (ex-military, students, members, etc.).
3. We kept the features that provided alternative methods for completing tasks. Features like the "Start Chat" and "Speech To Text Accessibility" buttons were described as major pleasure points by URUT and Rating Test participants.
4. We kept the general visual design, both typefaces (Helvetica Neue Thin) and colour palettes, the same. They were both favored by participants in the URUTs and visual design in general was described by participants as the category which required the least improvement going forward, as reflected by the average score of 7.4.

PAIN POINT & PLEASURE POINTS WIREFRAMES

HIGH-FIDELITY

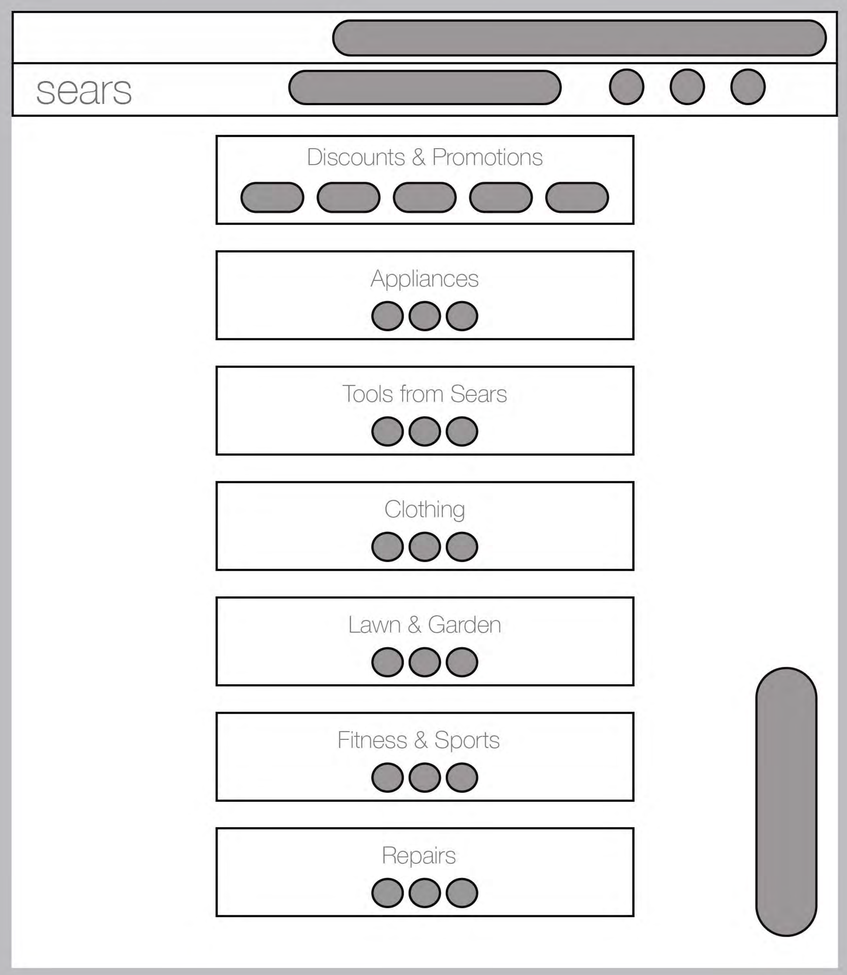
Attached

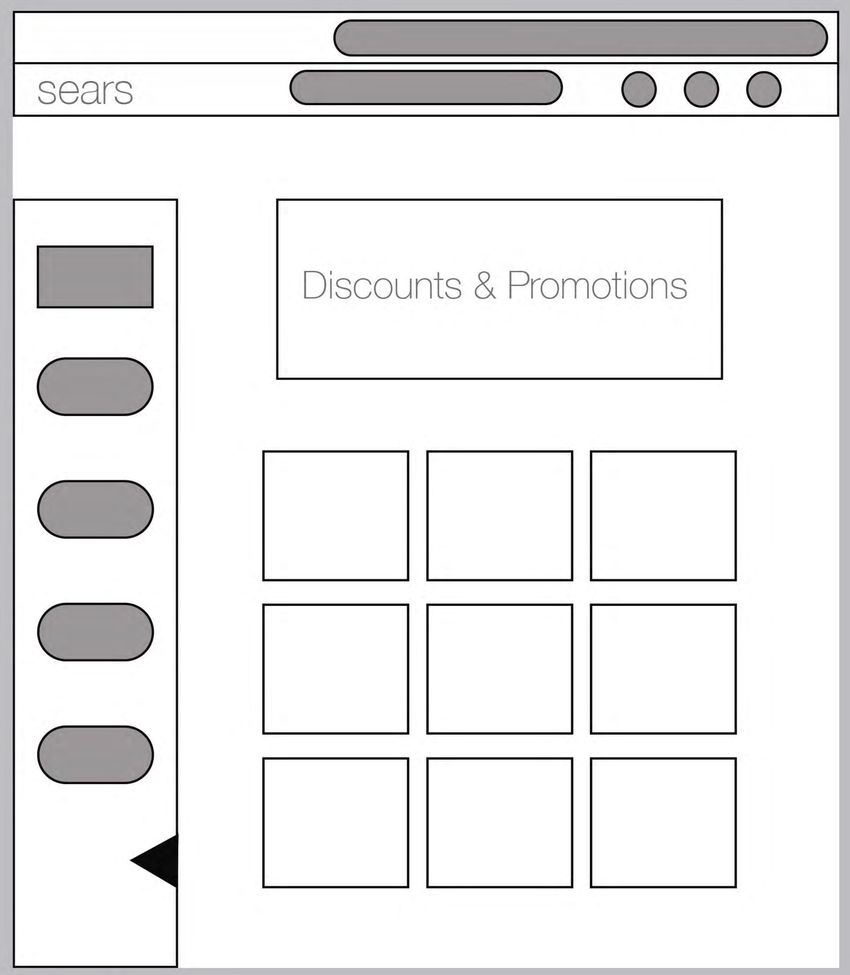
In the site's header, drop menus remain present; includes sections such as "Credit Card", "Donations", "Gift Cards", etc.

Again in the header, next to the "Search" Bar, buttons for "My Orders", "Profile" and "My Cart".

Separate section/tab for "Discounts & Promotions" to reduce site overcrowdedness while maintaining Sears value proposition.

Reorganization of visual hierarchy of information.





"Start Chat" feature; utilizes AI which can any certain customer questions.

Sidebar which can be used to filter customer's desired discounts and promotions; includes filters such as "Veterans", "Students", "Sears Members" and "By Product".

PAIN POINT & PLEASURE POINTS WIREFRAMES

DESIGN MOCKUP

Attached

sears

Search

Discounts & Promotions

Appliances

Tools from Sears

Clothing

Lawn & Garden

Fitness & Sports

Repairs

Start Chat

sears

Search

Filter By:

Veterans

Students

Sears Members

By Products

Discounts & Promotions